

Invest for Long-Term Wealth Building

The main long-term goal as you work toward financial independence is to invest wisely. Remember, the millionaires we studied didn't build their wealth in risky investments, sophisticated market strategies, or crazy real estate schemes. More millionaires say the 401(k) has played the largest role in building their net worth compared to other investing products. In fact, the 401(k) has made more of a difference than basic saving, real estate, inheritance, and selling a business *combined*. Focusing on that slow-and-steady, long-term goal isn't always easy, though. Building wealth requires personal responsibility, intentionality, and goals—not to mention sacrifice. But you—yes, *you*—have what it takes. In order to invest, you must make daily decisions to not spend your money on something fun or flashy, something that would make your life more enjoyable *today*. Although it can be difficult in the moment, it's really that simple. And when you invest, you're choosing an unbelievably awesome future over a marginally improved present.

Millionaires work hard for their money, but they also know how to let their money work hard for them. That only happens when you inject some discipline into your budget and make whatever sacrifices you need to make in the short term to free up money to invest for the long term. That echoes the advice that Will, one of the millionaires we interviewed in our study, gave to us. “Not having a plan to become a millionaire will keep people from ever becoming one,” he warns. Becoming a millionaire is a goal, and it's a goal Will worked toward for most of his life.